

was hugely influential. Pierre Boulez saw it as a cornerstone of modern music.

In terms of career development, the link with Maeterlinck was more crucial. Debussy saw his play *Pelléas et Mélisande* in 1893 and soon decided that it would make a suitable subject for an opera. It took almost a decade before he was able to turn this into reality, and the production was almost derailed by an argument over one of its stars. Maeterlinck thought that the part of *Mélisande* would be sung by his mistress, Georgette Leblanc. Debussy, however, preferred the Scottish soprano Mary Garden. He had already dedicated two songs to her in his *Ariettes oubliées* (*Forgotten Songs*, 1885–1887). The composer had his way, but it created a long-lasting rift between the two men. There was talk of legal action and even a duel, but in the end the matter was resolved.

When the first performance of the opera finally went ahead, its success transformed Debussy's reputation and encouraged reviewers to start exploring the vast back-catalog of his music. In *Pelléas*, he had created a hauntingly beautiful accompaniment to Maeterlinck's enigmatic tale. By this stage, he had purged the most obvious Wagnerian influences from his style. Instead, his opera carried echoes of *Boris Godunov* (1869) by Modest Mussorgsky, whose music Debussy had discovered in the mid-1890s.

Turbulent relations

In contrast to Debussy's successful career, his personal life was in tatters. The main issue concerned his first wife, Lily. The